

private schools their children attended. Both enjoy vintage wines, gourmet foods, entertaining, high-quality jewelry, and foreign travel.

Their neighbors think Lamar and Mary are wealthy. Some are firmly convinced that they are multimillionaires. But looks can be deceiving. They are not wealthy. Do they at least earn a high income? No, neither the husband nor the wife earns a high income. Mary is a housewife. Lamar is an administrator at the local college. Never in the couple's long marriage have the two ever had an earned annual income in excess of \$60,000, even though they have a lifestyle similar to those with incomes of at least twice theirs.

Some may suggest that this couple does an outstanding job of budgeting and planning. How else can they live so high with so few dollars of income? But Lamar and Mary have never put a budget plan together in all the years they've been married. They spend in excess of their income every year. They also spend all the money Mary receives from her parents. In short, Mary and Lamar are able to live so lavishly because they are the recipients of what we call economic outpatient care (EOC). Economic outpatient care refers to the substantial economic gifts and "acts of kindness" some parents give their adult children and grandchildren. This chapter will explore the implications of economic outpatient care, and how it affects the lives of those who give it and those who receive it.